INTRODUCTION

Soon after the conclusion of the Second World War, the world was engulfed in a different sort of a struggle for global leadership between the two former allies, the United States and the erstwhile Soviet Union. Both emerged as superpowers immediately after the Second World War. Great Britain was exhausted and no longer was able to hold on to the position of a global power. Germany being partitioned and Japan being devastated by atomic bombs, failed to emerge as great powers. This left only the United States and the Soviet Union to play a decisive role in the international scenario. However, the relation between the two became strained for a number of reasons and assumed the form of **Cold War**, which was short of hot war. This resulted in the bifurcation of the world into two rival blocs and creation of a number of military alliances and counter alliances. Though there was a temporary thaw in their relations, regarded as détente, but that too was short-lived and soon degenerated into another round of tensions and strained relations, often called **New Cold War.** Ultimately, the Cold War ended in 1990, with the dismemberment of the former Soviet Union.